

South Africa: Market Entry Playbooks

The practical companion to the market insight report: how to actually get into each market, what to aim for year by year, how your KPIs should evolve, how clients are won and kept, and how to keep growing for the next 10-20 years.

Generated 2026-07-04. Figures are realistic planning corridors for a competent, adequately funded operator - they are targets to manage against, not promises. Sectors are ordered by current market health (best first).

How to use these playbooks

- **Steps** are sequenced - skipping early steps (offtake, licences, cash buffers) is the most common cause of failure in every sector.
- **Year-by-year targets** are corridors: landing inside the range means you're on track; missing the bottom of a range two phases running means change the plan.
- **"Fast but safe" scaling** in practice means: never outgrow your cash runway, your compliance, or your ability to deliver quality - the roadmaps encode all three.
- Cross-reference the main insight report for each market's current health, failure data and capital requirements.

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1. ICT, Software & Digital Services

The smart way in: Enter as a specialist services firm earning rand, then convert to offshore clients earning pounds/dollars, then productise into recurring revenue.

How to get in — step by step

1 Pick a vertical, not a technology

Choose one industry you'll serve (logistics, healthcare admin, body corporates, agri) and one painful workflow in it. 'Full-stack dev shop' is a race to the bottom; 'we automate claims admin for medical practices' commands 3x the rate.

2 Register and set up lean

CIPC company (R175), SARS tax + VAT once over R1m turnover, business bank account, professional indemnity insurance (~R6k-R15k/yr). No office - work remote, meet clients on-site.

3 Land 2-3 anchor clients before hiring anyone

Use your network, past employers, and direct outreach. Anchor clients on monthly retainers (R25k-R80k) fund everything else. Never start with one client >50% of revenue.

4 Build the delivery bench slowly

First hires: one mid-level dev and one junior per ~R150k/month of contracted revenue. Salaries are your only real cost - keep 4-6 months of payroll banked before each hire.

5 Go offshore within 18 months

List on Clutch/Upwork Enterprise, join UK/EU agency-partner networks, use SA's timezone pitch (GMT+2 = live overlap with Europe). One UK client at £450-£650/day per dev doubles your margin overnight.

6 Productise by year 3

Take the workflow you've now built 5 times and turn it into a licensed product or hosted SaaS with monthly billing. Services fund the build; the product is what scales.

Your roadmap: what to hit, year by year

PHASE	FOCUS	REALISTIC TARGETS
Year 1	Prove billable demand solo/tiny	- Revenue R600k-R1.5m (you + 1-2 devs) 2-3 retainer clients, none >50% of revenue - Utilisation of billable people >65% - Effective rate >R650/hour blended 6 months' payroll in the bank by December
Years 2-3	Team of 5-10, first offshore revenue	- Revenue R3m-R8m, gross margin >45% - Offshore clients = 25-40% of revenue - Recurring (retainer/support) revenue >30% - Revenue per developer >R1.2m/year - Client concentration: top client <35%
Years 4-5	Specialist firm with a product line	- Revenue R12m-R30m, EBITDA 15-20% - Product/SaaS revenue >15% and growing - Offshore >40% of revenue (rand hedge) - Team 15-30 with 2 delivery leads (you're out of delivery) - Net revenue retention >100% on recurring base
Years 6-10	Scale-up: agency + product engine	- Revenue R40m-R120m or SaaS ARR R15m-R50m - EBITDA 20%+ services / rule-of-40 on SaaS 3+ verticals or 2+ export markets - Senior team owns sales - founder on strategy/M&A - Consider acquiring 1-2 small shops for capability
Years 10-20	Regional platform or exit	- Either: sell to an international integrator (services trade at 5-8x EBITDA, SaaS at 3-6x revenue) - or build an African platform via AfCFTA - AI-native service lines replacing headcount-based pricing with outcome pricing - Talent academy feeding your own pipeline (SETA-funded learnerships)

How your KPIs change as you grow

Startup (years 1-2)

- Utilisation >65% of billable hours
- Blended rate >R650/hr
- Cash runway >4 months always
- Proposal win rate >30%

Growth (years 3-5)

- Revenue per head >R1.2m
- Recurring revenue >30%
- Offshore revenue share >35%
- Staff attrition <15%/yr
- Gross margin >45%

Scale (years 6-10+)

- EBITDA >20%
- Net revenue retention >105%
- Founder-free sales: >70% of new deals closed without you
- Product revenue >25%
- Pipeline coverage 3x quarterly target

How clients are actually won and kept

Outbound — go get them

- Direct LinkedIn + email to CTOs/CFOs in your vertical: lead with a diagnostic ('we found 4 hours/week of manual work in firms like yours'), not capability lists
- Partner channels: Microsoft/AWS partner directories, accounting firms and consultancies who refer their clients' tech problems
- UK/EU agency subcontracting marketplaces (YunoJuno, Distributed, agency-to-agency deals) to land offshore work before you have a brand
- Respond to RFPs/tenders selectively - private sector only until you have cash buffers for government payment terms

Inbound — make them come

- One deep case study per anchor client with real numbers - this is the highest-ROI marketing asset in B2B services
- SEO on vertical problem terms ('practice management integration South Africa'), not generic 'software development'
- Speak at the vertical's industry events (logistics conferences, medical practice management seminars) - not tech meetups; your buyers aren't there
- Open-source a small tool your vertical uses; it ranks, builds trust, and feeds leads

Retention — keep them

- Convert every project to a support retainer at handover (aim 60%+ conversion)
- Quarterly business reviews showing value delivered in rand saved/earned
- Product roadmap co-design with top clients - they fund features and can't leave
- Fix the key-person risk: 2 people minimum on every account

The 10-20 year game

- AI will deflate hourly-rate coding - move pricing to outcomes and retained products early
- SA's durable advantage is talent cost + timezone + English: build the offshore pipe, and own a niche where domain knowledge (not code volume) is the moat
- Data-residency and POPIA-type compliance work grows for 20 years as Africa regulates
- Exit optionality: international integrators buy vertical specialists, not generalists

2. Transport & Logistics

The smart way in: Enter with contracted vehicles (never speculative), niche into cold chain or last-mile density, then build the 3PL layer where the real margins live.

How to get in — step by step

- 1 Secure the contract before the vehicle**
A truck without a lane is a liability shedding R30k+/month. Get a signed contract or sub-contract (courier networks, FMCG distributors, e-com fulfilment) first, then finance the vehicle against it.
- 2 Set up compliant from day one**
CIPC + GIT (goods-in-transit) insurance + operating licences where applicable + RTMS accreditation as you grow. Big clients audit insurance and roadworthiness before awarding lanes.
- 3 Start where density or specialisation pays**
Metro last-mile (e-com parcels, pharma), cold chain (food/agri exports), or specialised loads (dangerous goods, outsize). Avoid general long-haul - it's a rate-war with owner-drivers.
- 4 Engineer out the empty legs**
Backhaul agreements and load-matching platforms from vehicle #1. Loaded-km percentage is the single biggest lever on profit.
- 5 Add the warehouse when clients ask twice**
Cross-dock/fulfilment space converts you from commodity transporter to 3PL with sticky contracts and storage + pick-pack margins.
- 6 Protect the downside ruthlessly**
Fuel-price escalation clauses in every contract, telematics + driver vetting for hijack risk, no client >40% of revenue, maintenance fund of 8-10% of revenue.

Your roadmap: what to hit, year by year

PHASE	FOCUS	REALISTIC TARGETS
Year 1	2-4 vehicles, all contracted	- Revenue R1.8m-R4m, EBITDA >10% - Loaded km >80%; cost per km tracked weekly - Zero uninsured incidents; GIT + liability current 1 anchor contract + 2 secondary revenue streams - Driver retention 100% (pay above market, they're the business)
Years 2-3	Fleet 8-15, niche established	- Revenue R8m-R20m, EBITDA 12-15% - OTIF >95% measured and reported to clients monthly - Fuel spread (revenue/km minus cost/km) >R6 long-haul or cost per parcel <R35 metro last-mile - First warehouse/cross-dock (1,000-3,000m²) - Client concentration: top client <40%
Years 4-5	3PL with contracts	- Revenue R30m-R70m; storage + value-added services >20% of revenue - Fleet 20-40 + owner-driver network for peaks - WMS/TMS systems live - data is what wins corporate tenders 2-3 year contracted revenue >60% of book - EBITDA 15%+
Years 6-10	Network operator	- Revenue R100m-R300m, multi-node DC network - Cross-border SADC lanes (Zim/Zam/Moz/Bots corridors) >15% of revenue - Private rail siding/slot participation as Transnet opens access - Tech layer: client portals, API integrations to e-com platforms - Consider acquiring niche competitors (cold chain books trade well)
Years 10-20	Infrastructure-grade logistics	- Rail-linked terminals and port-adjacent facilities as concessions mature - Regional corridor operations under AfCFTA volume growth - EV/alternative-fuel fleet transition (cost advantage arrives ~2030s) - Exit: strategic sale to a global 3PL entering Africa (they buy networks, not trucks) or private equity roll-up

How your KPIs change as you grow

Startup (years 1-2)

- Loaded km >80%
- Cost per km vs revenue per km spread >R6
- Vehicle utilisation >22 days/month
- Breakdown downtime <3%

Growth (years 3-5)

- OTIF >95%
- EBITDA >12%
- Claims/damage <0.5% of revenue
- Contracted revenue >60%
- Driver attrition <20%/yr

Scale (years 6-10+)

- Revenue per vehicle >R2m/yr
- Warehouse utilisation >85%
- Revenue from value-added services >25%
- Debt service cover >2x
- Cross-border share >15%

How clients are actually won and kept

Outbound — go get them

- Target supply-chain managers at FMCG/retail/pharma with a specific lane proposal and your OTIF data - specificity beats capability brochures
- Sub-contract to established 3PLs and courier networks (The Courier Guy, DSV overflow) to build volume history that wins your own contracts later
- Tender for retail DC-to-store and e-com fulfilment contracts once you have 12 months of performance data
- Agri exporters and packhouses for cold-chain lanes - approach before harvest season with reefer capacity commitments

Inbound — make them come

- Case studies with hard numbers: OTIF, damage rates, cost per parcel vs the client's previous provider
- Google Business + SEO for '[niche] transport [city]' - surprisingly uncontested for specialised terms
- Industry association membership (SAAFF, RFA) where corporate shippers look for vetted providers
- Referrals from warehouse landlords, clearing agents and packaging suppliers who hear about capacity needs first

Retention — keep them

- Monthly performance packs (OTIF, claims, cost trends) before the client asks - transparency wins renewals
- Integrate into their systems (EDI/API) - switching costs keep contracts
- Fuel-price escalation clauses protect margin so you never degrade service to survive a diesel spike
- Dedicated account contact + WhatsApp visibility groups for operational trust

The 10-20 year game

- Transnet reform is the decade's opportunity: private rail access, port concessions and rail-adjacent property will mint the next logistics fortunes
- E-commerce last-mile grows 20%/yr for the foreseeable future - density compounds into unassailable unit economics
- AfCFTA corridor volumes make cross-border capability increasingly valuable
- The end-state asset is the network + contracts + data, not the vehicles - keep the balance sheet light and the relationships heavy

3. Financial Services & Fintech

The smart way in: Enter with a licensed, revenue-first niche (advisory practice or SME-focused product), distribute through partners rather than ads, and let the licence moat compound.

How to get in — step by step

- 1 Choose your regulatory lane first**
Advisory/brokerage: FSP licence (Cat I) with RE5 exams - cheapest entry, income from day one. Payments: partner with a licensed sponsor (bank BIN or TPPP). Lending: NCR registration. Insurance: cell captive or UMA under an insurer's licence. The lane decides everything downstream.
- 2 Start under someone else's licence**
Join an existing FSP as a representative, or build your product on a sponsor's rails (Stitch/Peach for payments, a cell captive for insurance). You trade margin for 12-18 months of speed and compliance cover.
- 3 Pick an underserved segment with money**
SMEs (the R350bn credit gap), informal traders (device insurance, stock finance via spaza platforms), gig workers, stokvels, SADC remitters. Avoid competing with banks for salaried consumers - CAC will kill you.
- 4 Get to revenue before raising**
SA funding is scarce and dilutive pre-revenue. A book of 50 advisory clients or an SME product with R100k MRR beats any deck. Bootstrap or take angel money only.
- 5 Embed distribution - never buy it retail**
Partner with whoever already has your customer's trust: retailers, telcos, employers, accountants, franchise networks, industry associations. Rev-share beats paid ads on every metric in SA.
- 6 Build the compliance function early**
FICA, POPIA, and (incoming) COFI compliance done properly is a moat - subscale competitors can't afford it and partners audit it before signing.

Your roadmap: what to hit, year by year

PHASE	FOCUS	REALISTIC TARGETS
Year 1	Licensed and earning	• Advisory: 60-120 clients, R600k-R1.5m revenue Product: live with 1 distribution partner, 1,000-5,000 users • Compliance: zero findings; FICA/KYC processes documented • Unit economics mapped: know your CAC and payback per channel • 12+ months runway maintained
Years 2-3	Repeatable distribution	• Advisory: AUA R50m-R150m, recurring fees >60% of income Product: MRR R200k-R1m, 2-3 embedded partners • LTV/CAC >3x proven on at least one channel • Default/loss rate <8% if lending; claims ratio <60% if insurance • Team 5-15 incl. dedicated compliance officer
Years 4-5	Scale the winning channel	• Advisory: AUA R300m-R600m, practice revenue R5m-R12m Product: MRR R1.5m-R5m, 50k-250k users • Own licence upgrade complete (own FSP/NCR/insurance cell) • Second product line cross-sold to the same base (>15% attach rate) • EBITDA positive or funded through Series A (R30m-R100m rounds are realistic here)
Years 6-10	Multi-product platform	• Revenue R30m-R150m; users 250k-1m+ or AUA R1bn+ • 3+ products per customer relationship (lending + insurance + payments) • Bank/insurer partnership or acquisition interest - banks buy distribution they can't build • SADC corridor expansion (start with remittance/trade lanes you already touch)
Years 10-20	Regional financial platform or strategic exit	• African multi-market presence via AfCFTA financial services protocols • Banking-as-a-service or full licence if economics justify (R50m+ capital) • Exit paths: bank acquisition (strategic premium), PE consolidation of advisory books (2.5-4x recurring revenue), or listed via JSE AltX

How your KPIs change as you grow

Startup (years 1-2)

- CAC payback <12 months
- Activation rate >40% of sign-ups
- Compliance findings: zero
- MRR growth >15%/month off small base

Growth (years 3-5)

- LTV/CAC >3x
- NPL <8% / claims ratio <60%
- Churn <3%/month
- Revenue per employee >R1m
- Partner-sourced share of new business >60%

Scale (years 6-10+)

- Products per customer >2
- Cost-to-income ratio <60%
- Cohort LTV still rising at month 24
- Capital adequacy comfortably above minimums
- Regulatory relationships: proactive, not reactive

How clients are actually won and kept

Outbound — go get them

- Partnership-first outbound: pitch retailers/telcos/employer groups/accounting networks on rev-share embedded products - one partner = thousands of users
- For advisory: structured referral agreements with accountants, attorneys and estate agents; run retirement/tax workshops at employers
- SME lending: work trade associations and franchisors whose members share transaction data patterns you can underwrite
- Conference presence where your partners (not consumers) gather: retail, telco, HR and franchise industry events

Inbound — make them come

- Calculators and tools that answer money questions (retirement gap, business loan affordability) - SA search volume is huge and trust transfers
- Vernacular content and WhatsApp-first onboarding for mass-market products
- Media commentary on rates/budget/two-pot - journalists need quotable experts, and authority compounds
- Client testimonials with real outcomes (approved loan, paid claim) - trust is the entire product in financial services

Retention — keep them

- Annual reviews that show value in rand (fees vs returns, premiums vs claims paid)
- Product depth: every added product halves churn - engineer the second-product moment into month 3-6
- Proactive service on life events (claims, renewals, rate changes) - the moments that decide loyalty
- For partners: quarterly performance packs proving their rev-share is growing

The 10-20 year game

- Open banking + PayShap re-plumb SA finance over the next decade - build on the new rails, not the old ones
- The informal economy formalises slowly but inevitably; whoever holds those customer relationships at scale becomes an acquisition target
- Compliance burden keeps rising - it crushes small players and protects established ones; get established
- SA is the fintech gateway to a 1.4bn-person continent; SADC first, then AfCFTA lanes

4. Energy & Renewables

The smart way in: Enter through C&I solar installation with certified skills, build an O&M annuity book, then graduate to storage, wheeling and small IPP development.

How to get in — step by step

- 1 Get the paperwork that wins bids**
PV GreenCard training, a registered Master Electrician for CoCs (hire or partner), SAPVIA membership, CIPC + tax clearance + B-BBEE affidavit. C&I clients and insurers check all of it.
- 2 Start as a subcontract install crew**
Do 6-12 months installing for established EPCs. You learn pricing, standards and supplier terms on someone else's balance sheet - and you see which niches are underserved.
- 3 Pick the commercial & industrial niche, skip residential**
Residential is saturated post-loadshedding. Target factories, farms (irrigation + cold rooms), body corporates, schools, lodges: 30-200kWp systems, R400k-R3m tickets, payback logic sells itself at current tariffs.
- 4 Solve the financing objection before it's raised**
Partner with solar finance providers (rent-to-own, PPA funds) so capex-shy clients can sign at RO upfront. The installer who brings financing closes 2-3x more.
- 5 Attach O&M to every install**
Monitoring + cleaning + insurance-repair contract at 1-2% of system value/year. This annuity is what makes the business sellable later.
- 6 Add storage and energy services from year 3**
BESS retrofits, tariff optimisation, and (as market rules open) wheeling/trading partnerships. Register early interest with NERSA processes via a trading partner.

Your roadmap: what to hit, year by year

PHASE	FOCUS	REALISTIC TARGETS
Year 1	Certified crew, first direct clients	• 8-15 C&I installs (or 30-50 subcontracted), revenue R2m-R5m • Gross margin >22% on own projects • Zero CoC/compliance failures • 3 finance-partner agreements signed • O&M contracts on >50% of own installs
Years 2-3	C&I brand with an O&M base	• Revenue R8m-R20m, 25-40 projects/yr • O&M annuity book R500k-R1.5m/yr and growing • Quote-to-close >25% on referred leads • 1 anchor segment owned (e.g. agri in your province) • Stock turn >6x - never warehouse panels speculatively
Years 4-5	Storage + larger projects	• Revenue R30m-R70m, EBITDA 12-18% • BESS attached to >40% of new projects • First 1-5MW ground-mount as EPC or co-developer • O&M book >R4m/yr (this is your valuation anchor) • Wheeling/PPA deal participation via trader partnerships
Years 6-10	Developer-operator	• Development pipeline 20-100MW (own 10-30% equity positions) • Recurring revenue (O&M + generation) >35% of total • Revenue R100m-R300m or asset-based returns replacing EPC margin • Grid-connection expertise as a paid service (the bottleneck is the business)
Years 10-20	Yield portfolio	• Own/co-own generating assets earning 15-25 year PPA income • Municipal distribution O&M concessions as they outsource • EV charging network positions on logistics corridors • Exit: sell the O&M book + pipeline to a utility-scale player (annuity books trade at 4-8x recurring revenue)

How your KPIs change as you grow

Startup (years 1-2)

- Installed cost R9-R14/Wp competitive
- GM per project >22%
- Installs per crew per month >3
- Referral rate >30% of new work

Growth (years 3-5)

- O&M contracts as % of installs >60%
- Quote-to-close >25%
- Project margin variance <5% vs quoted
- Days sales outstanding <45
- Callback/defect rate <3%

Scale (years 6-10+)

- Recurring revenue >35%
- MW under management growing 30%/yr
- Development pipeline conversion >20%
- EBITDA >15%
- Fleet performance ratio >80% across managed sites

How clients are actually won and kept

Outbound — go get them

- Free energy audits for factories/farms with a one-page payback model - the audit IS the sales call; aim at operations managers, not procurement
- Sector-by-sector campaigns: dairy co-ops, packhouses, private schools, lodges - one reference client per segment unlocks the rest via word of mouth
- Partner with electrical contractors, roofers and agri-equipment dealers who see the client's roof before you do (pay 3-5% referral fees)
- Body corporate AGM presentations with sectional-title-specific finance structures

Inbound — make them come

- Publish real production data from your installs (monthly kWh vs promise) - radical transparency beats every competitor's brochure
- Google Ads on 'commercial solar + [city]' with a payback calculator landing page
- Case studies with the client's actual saving in rand on the electricity bill
- Referral programme: one month's free O&M for every referred install

Retention — keep them

- Monitoring portal + WhatsApp alerts - clients who watch their generation daily never churn and buy batteries next
- Annual system health report with upsell path (storage, expansion, tariff review)
- Performance guarantees with skin in the game (credit shortfall vs promised yield)
- O&M contracts with 3-year terms and CPI escalation

The 10-20 year game

- Coal fleet retirement + grid constraints guarantee 15+ years of demand; the profit pool moves from installation (commoditising) to operations, storage and trading
- Position for the energy-trading era now: relationships with licensed traders, wheeling-ready client base, metering data ownership
- Municipal distribution failure = concession opportunity for credible private operators
- Own generating assets - the end-state is earning from electrons, not labour

5. Tourism & Hospitality

The smart way in: Enter capital-light through experiences and direct-booking skill, then buy/build accommodation once you own a guest pipeline, then consolidate into a multi-property brand or inbound operator.

How to get in — step by step

- 1 Start with experiences, not beds**
Tours, transfers, food/wine/township/adventure experiences need R50k-R500k, not R5m. You learn the guest, the seasonality and the channels before betting on property.
- 2 Get legal and listed**
Tour operator: registered guide (CATHSSETA) or hire guides, PDP-licensed vehicles, passenger liability insurance. List on GetYourGuide/Viator/Airbnb Experiences day one - their demand is instant, their 20-30% commission is tuition.
- 3 Master reviews as the core asset**
4.8+ on TripAdvisor/Google with 200+ reviews outranks any ad budget. Engineer the review ask into every tour's final 10 minutes.
- 4 Build direct booking muscle**
Own website with instant booking, WhatsApp Business, Google Business Profile. Shift from 100% OTA to 40%+ direct within 2 years - that margin difference funds growth.
- 5 Add accommodation against a known pipeline**
Once your experiences feed you guests, lease or buy a guesthouse where your guests already want to stay. Buy distressed/tired stock and refurbish - never pay for someone else's goodwill.
- 6 Package into itineraries**
Combine your beds + your experiences + partner products into multi-day packages sold to inbound agents and directly to source markets. Packaging doubles revenue per guest.

Your roadmap: what to hit, year by year

PHASE	FOCUS	REALISTIC TARGETS
Year 1	One excellent product, review velocity	• 500-1,500 guests, revenue R600k-R1.5m • Rating >4.8 with 150+ reviews across platforms • Direct bookings >20% by December • Repeat/referral bookings measurable (ask every guest how they found you) • Gross margin >55% on experiences
Years 2-3	Product range + first property	• Revenue R3m-R8m; 3-5 experience products • Direct bookings >40% (OTA commission saved = your marketing budget) • First accommodation: 6-12 rooms leased/bought, occupancy >55% year one • Shoulder-season revenue >25% of annual (corporate, domestic, MICE fill) • Database: 5,000+ past guests with email/WhatsApp consent
Years 4-5	Destination business	• Revenue R12m-R30m, EBITDA 18-25% • Occupancy >65% annualised; RevPAR at/above your STR comp set • Multi-day packages >30% of revenue • Inbound agent relationships in 3+ source markets (UK/DE/NL/US + India/China) • Second property or exclusive-use venue
Years 6-10	Brand or inbound operator at scale	• Revenue R40m-R120m; 3-6 properties or DMC handling 10k+ pax/yr • Direct + repeat + agent = 80% of bookings (OTA dependence broken) • Yield management running daily (dynamic pricing) • Own source-market representation (agent in UK/India) or niche authority (SA's best cycling/food/rail operator)
Years 10-20	Institutional asset	• Property portfolio with hospitality operating company split (opco/propco) - the structure funds expansion and enables exit • Asia volume: India/China direct packages as visa reform matures • Exit: hotel groups and PE buy occupancy track records and direct-booking engines; lodges trade on EBITDA multiples of 6-10x

How your KPIs change as you grow

Startup (years 1-2)

- Review rating >4.8, velocity >10/month
- Direct booking share >20%
- Gross margin >55% experiences
- Guest acquisition cost <10% of booking value

Growth (years 3-5)

- Occupancy >65%
- Direct >40%
- Revenue per guest growing 10%/yr
- Shoulder-season share >25%
- Repeat/referral >20% of bookings

Scale (years 6-10+)

- RevPAR vs comp set >100%
- EBITDA >20%
- Database conversion >5%/campaign
- Package attach rate >30%
- Staff retention >80% season-to-season

How clients are actually won and kept

Outbound — go get them

- Inbound tour operators and DMCs in source markets: pitch with commission structure, rate sheets and STO agreements before their planning seasons
- Corporate/MICE planners for shoulder-season groups (conferences, incentives, year-end functions)
- Partnerships with complementary operators (wine farms, transfer companies, restaurants) for cross-sell packages
- Travel trade shows: WTM Africa, Indaba - one good agent relationship pays for years of stands

Inbound — make them come

- OTA excellence first (photography, first 3 review pages, response times) - it's the discovery engine whether you like the commission or not
- Destination SEO content ('3 days in [town] itinerary') that captures planners before they hit OTAs
- Instagram/TikTok location content - travel is decided visually; user-generated content from guests outperforms produced content
- Google Business Profile + WhatsApp instant response (speed of reply predicts booking conversion more than price)

Retention — keep them

- Post-stay email/WhatsApp journeys: review ask → referral offer → return-visit offer at 10-11 months
- Guest database segmented by source market and interest - your list is the only channel with zero commission
- Loyalty pricing for direct repeat bookers (never discount via OTAs)
- Partnerships that keep you in the guest's trip even when beds are full (cross-referral with trusted competitors)

The 10-20 year game

- Weak rand makes SA structurally cheap for hard-currency travellers - a 20-year tailwind independent of domestic economics
- Visa reform + air access decide the Asia volume wave; position products for Indian and Chinese group travel now
- Climate/authenticity trends favour nature, township and cultural product - SA's unfair advantages
- The end-state asset is the direct-booking brand + guest database + property yield; OTA-dependent businesses never compound

6. Agriculture & Agro-processing

The smart way in: Enter through intensive high-value production or agri-services with secured offtake, then move up the chain into packing and processing where the margins and the defensibility live.

How to get in — step by step

- 1 Choose intensive over extensive**
You can't out-scale established commercial farmers on maize. Enter where management intensity beats hectares: tunnel vegetables, herbs, berries, mushrooms, poultry, or agri-services (spraying, scouting, pack labour).
- 2 Secure offtake before planting anything**
Signed programmes with packhouses, fresh produce agents, retailers' local supplier programmes (Shoprite/PnP local sourcing), or export agents. No offtake, no planting - this rule alone beats most failure modes.
- 3 Control water before land**
Verify water rights/borehole yield/municipal reliability first. Lease land (R2k-R8k/ha/yr dryland, more irrigated) rather than buying - capital belongs in production infrastructure, not soil.
- 4 Start at half the scale your budget allows**
First two seasons are tuition: pests, timing, market grading. Surviving season one matters more than maximising it. Keep 18 months of costs banked.
- 5 Get certified for the buyers who pay**
GlobalG.A.P. for export, HACCP for processing, SA-GAP for retail programmes. Certification is the gate between R8/kg local and R25/kg export.
- 6 Move up the chain deliberately**
Year 3-5: packhouse share or processing line (drying, freezing, juicing, value-added). Primary production margins are 8-15%; processing adds 20-35% and smooths seasonality.

Your roadmap: what to hit, year by year

PHASE	FOCUS	REALISTIC TARGETS
Year 1	First production cycles survived	• 0.5-2ha intensive (or services book), revenue R400k-R1.2m • Offtake agreements covering >70% of planned volume • Class 1/A-grade pass rate >70% (learning curve) • Water security verified and backup plan tested • Cost per kg tracked per crop cycle - know your break-even cold
Years 2-3	Consistent quality, growing programmes	• 3-8ha or equivalent, revenue R2m-R6m • Class 1 rate >80%; rejection rate <8% • 2+ buyers so no single offtake >60% • GlobalG.A.P./SA-GAP certification achieved • Gross margin >35% on core crops; debt service cover >1.5x
Years 4-5	Packhouse economics	• Revenue R8m-R25m; export or retail programme volume >30% • Packhouse share/own line: earning packing margin on your + neighbours' fruit • Yield within 10% of top-quartile benchmarks for your crops • Crop insurance + forward cover on inputs (fuel, fertiliser) standard • Second production site or crop for seasonal spread
Years 6-10	Agri-business, not farm	• Revenue R30m-R100m across production + packing + services • Processing line converting B-grade into value-added products (30%+ margin) • Own brand into retail or export programmes under your label • Outgrower network: your packhouse + inputs + agronomy supporting 5-20 smaller farmers (volume without capex) • AfCFTA/Middle East export lanes opened (halaal certification where relevant)
Years 10-20	Vertically integrated food company	• Brand + processing + farming + outgrower supply = food company economics (these trade at 6-10x EBITDA vs farmland yields) • Water and climate resilience infrastructure (storage, drip, shade net) as the compounding moat • Land acquisition now makes sense - buy the soil your business proved • Exit/partnership: agri-corporates and PE funds buy integrated operations with export books

How your KPIs change as you grow

Startup (years 1-2)

- Class 1 pass rate >70%
- Offtake coverage >70% of volume
- Cost per kg vs market price margin >25%
- Cash runway >12 months

Growth (years 3-5)

- Yield per ha within 10% of benchmark
- Class 1 >80%
- Water cost per ton falling
- Gross margin >35%
- Debt service cover >1.5x through worst season

Scale (years 6-10+)

- Processing/packing margin >20% of revenue
- Export share >30%
- Outgrower volume >25% of throughput
- EBITDA >15%
- Climate loss events <5% of revenue (insurance + infrastructure)

How clients are actually won and kept

Outbound — go get them

- Packhouses, export agents and fresh produce market agents before each season - bring samples, certifications and volume commitments
- Retail local-sourcing programmes (Shoprite, PnP, SPAR DCs actively recruit local growers - smaller volumes accepted than people assume)
- Restaurants/hotel groups for premium direct programmes (herbs, specialty veg at 2x wholesale)
- Neighbouring commercial farmers for services revenue (your equipment/labour in their off-peak = cash flow smoothing)

Inbound — make them come

- Be findable when buyers search: Google Business, Farmer's Weekly/agri publications, provincial agri associations (buyers scout there)
- Show the operation: farm open days and social media of your practices - buyers audit informally before they call
- List on fresh-produce trading platforms (Nile.ag, agri marketplaces) for spot-volume discovery
- Word of mouth via agronomists, input suppliers and packhouse managers - keep them close, they broker everything informally

Retention — keep them

- Never short a programme: if you promised 10 tons, deliver 10 - buyers forgive price negotiation, never unreliability
- Consistent grading and cold-chain discipline (one bad pallet costs a season's trust)
- Season-ahead planning meetings with each buyer (their promotions calendar = your planting calendar)
- Transparent problem communication: call the buyer before they discover the hail damage

The 10-20 year game

- Food demand + weak rand + AfCFTA = 20-year export tailwind; SA's counter-seasonal window to the northern hemisphere is permanent
- Water is the binding constraint - every rand into water efficiency and storage compounds for decades
- Climate volatility rewards protected cropping (tunnels, nets) and diversified geography - build both
- The wealth is in the chain, not the field: packing, processing, brand, logistics - integrate relentlessly

7. Retail, Wholesale & E-commerce

The smart way in: Enter online-first in a niche category (or via a proven franchise), build margin through private label, then go omnichannel where the chains can't follow.

How to get in — step by step

- 1 Choose niche depth over general width**
Pick a category with passion + repeat purchase + import inefficiency (pet specialty, outdoor gear, hair care, halaal foods, baby). You must be the most knowledgeable seller in it, not the cheapest.
- 2 Validate with R30k-R100k, not a store**
Land 50-200 units of stock, sell via Takealot Marketplace + Instagram/WhatsApp + Facebook Marketplace. If you can't sell R50k/month from a spare room, a store won't save you.
- 3 Set up the boring infrastructure**
CIPC, SARS (import code if importing), Payfast/Yoco payments, a Shopify/WooCommerce store, courier accounts (The Courier Guy, Pudo lockers). Unit economics sheet: landed cost, CAC, delivery, returns - per SKU.
- 4 Win on availability and service, not price**
Same-day dispatch, WhatsApp answers in minutes, easy returns. SA online shoppers pay for reliability because it's scarce.
- 5 Private label at proven volume**
Once a category sells 300+ units/month, import your own brand (Alibaba/local manufacturers): margin jumps from 25-35% to 50-65% and you become un-undercuttable.
- 6 Add physical presence where your data says**
Pop-ups, then a store or franchise in the node where your delivery heatmap is densest. Alternatively: franchise entry (R800k-R3m) is the lower-risk physical route - 60%+ 5-year survival vs ~20% independent.

Your roadmap: what to hit, year by year

PHASE	FOCUS	REALISTIC TARGETS
Year 1	Prove the niche online	• GMV R600k-R2m; gross margin >30% • CAC payback <2 orders; repeat purchase rate >20% • Same-day dispatch >95%; rating >4.6 on marketplaces • 300+ WhatsApp/email subscribers buying monthly • 3 hero SKUs identified for private label
Years 2-3	Brand + private label	• Revenue R4m-R12m; private label >30% of sales at >50% margin • Repeat rate >30%; email/WhatsApp drive >25% of orders (owned, not paid) • Stock turns >6x; dead stock <5% • Marketplace + own-site + social commerce all >20% of sales each • First pop-up/store trading profitably in month 3
Years 4-5	Omnichannel category leader	• Revenue R15m-R50m, EBITDA 8-12% • 2-4 stores in data-proven nodes; store payback <24 months • Private label >50% of revenue • Township/pick-up point network live (Pudo/Pargo + own points) • Category search: you rank top 3 for your niche terms nationally
Years 6-10	Chain or house of brands	• Revenue R80m-R250m • 8-20 stores or dominant online share of the category • Own distribution (mini-DC) once volume justifies • Second brand launched into adjacent category using same infrastructure • B2B/wholesale line supplying independents and salons/vets/gyms (per niche)
Years 10-20	Platform economics	• African expansion via marketplace exports (AfCFTA e-commerce protocols) before physical stores • Recommerce/circular line (trade-in, refurb) as cost-of-living reshapes demand • Exit: strategic sale to a retail group buying your category authority + private-label margins, or PE (retail brands trade 4-8x EBITDA)

How your KPIs change as you grow

Startup (years 1-2)

- CAC payback <2 orders
- Repeat rate >20%
- Gross margin >30%
- Dispatch same-day >95%

Growth (years 3-5)

- Repeat rate >30%
- Private label share >40%
- Stock turns >6x
- Owned-channel revenue >25%
- Return rate <8%

Scale (years 6-10+)

- EBITDA >10%
- Revenue per store vs rent ratio >10x
- NPS >50
- Basket growth beating inflation
- New-brand revenue >15%

How clients are actually won and kept

Outbound — go get them

- B2B outreach to the trade around your niche (vets for pet, salons for hair, schools for stationery) - wholesale anchors cash flow
- WhatsApp broadcast lists (opt-in) with weekly drops - SA's highest-converting retail channel, treat it like gold
- Influencer seeding: 20 micro-influencers (5k-50k followers) in your niche beats one celebrity; pay in product + commission codes
- Corporate gifting and stokvel/group-buying offers around pay cycles and Dec/Jan and Easter peaks

Inbound — make them come

- Rank for niche buying-intent terms ('best [product] South Africa') with genuine comparison content - low competition, high conversion
- Marketplace optimisation: reviews, Q&A, listing quality on Takealot/Amazon SA - the search bar inside marketplaces is your biggest free channel
- TikTok/Instagram Reels product demos - social commerce discovery drives SA niche retail now
- Google Shopping ads on exact SKUs (high intent, measurable ROAS - keep ROAS >4 or kill the ad)

Retention — keep them

- Replenishment reminders timed to product life (consumables are retention gold - engineer subscriptions with a discount)
- Loyalty in rand, not points ('R50 off your 5th order' beats schemes nobody understands)
- Post-purchase WhatsApp care (usage tips, warranty registration) that makes the second purchase feel obvious
- Community: WhatsApp/Facebook groups around the passion (pet owners, runners) - communities don't price-compare

The 10-20 year game

- E-commerce penetration doubles again this decade off SA's low base - infrastructure (lockers, payments) is finally in place
- Chains consolidate the middle; survivors are niche authorities and township-embedded operators - be one of those two
- Private label + owned audience = the only durable retail margins
- Watch Temu/Shein economics: never compete on generic imported goods; curation, service, trust and local relevance are the moat

8. BPO & Global Business Services

The smart way in: Enter with a small offshore-focused pod via aggregators, nail attrition and quality metrics, then scale seats into specialised verticals where AI augments rather than replaces.

How to get in — step by step

- 1 Learn the trade inside first**
Run a campaign or ops team in an existing BPO for 6-12 months if you haven't. This business is won or lost on operational discipline you can't learn from outside.
- 2 Start with a 5-15 seat pod, not a call centre**
Rent seats in a serviced BPO facility or run work-from-home with monitoring tools. Capex under R500k. Building a 100-seat floor before contracts is the classic failure.
- 3 Get offshore work via aggregators and brokers**
Direct UK/US/AUS clients won't sign an unknown - go through BPO brokers, outsourcing marketplaces and referral partners who take 5-15% but hand you campaigns. Domestic campaigns pay half; use them only to keep seats warm.
- 4 Register for the GBS incentive early**
The dtic GBS incentive pays up to ~R1.1k/job/month for qualifying offshore jobs - it materially changes unit economics. Get compliant (job creation reporting) from the start.
- 5 Specialise within 24 months**
Pick a vertical: healthcare admin, legal process, fintech compliance ops, e-commerce CX. Specialist seats bill 30-60% above generic voice and resist AI displacement.
- 6 Build the talent engine**
Recruitment + 4-6 week training academy + team-lead pipeline. Attrition is the profit killer; the operators who solve it (career paths, transport, culture) win.

Your roadmap: what to hit, year by year

PHASE	FOCUS	REALISTIC TARGETS
Year 1	Prove delivery on 5-15 seats	- Revenue R1.5m-R4m; 1-2 campaigns via brokers - Seat utilisation >85%; QA scores >90% of client target - Attrition <40% annualised - GBS incentive registration complete - One client reference letter you can show
Years 2-3	50-100 seats, direct offshore clients	- Revenue R10m-R30m; offshore >70% of seats - Revenue per seat >R20k/month offshore - First direct (non-brokered) international client - Attrition <35%; team leads promoted from within >80% - No client >40% of seats
Years 4-5	Vertical specialist, 150-350 seats	- Revenue R40m-R100m, EBITDA 12-18% 2 specialised verticals with premium billing - AI-assisted workflows live (agent-assist, QA automation) - pitch as productivity, bill on outcomes - Second-city delivery site (Gqeberha/Durban cost advantage) - Impact-sourcing credentials documented (township talent %, training hours)
Years 6-10	500-1,500 seats or outcome-based services	- Revenue R150m-R500m - Blended human+AI service lines: billing per resolution/outcome, not per hour - Client mix across UK/US/AUS - currency and cycle diversification - Own training academy with SETA funding feeding 100% of hiring - M&A: bolt-on niche providers or be bolted on (BPOs trade at 4-7x EBITDA)
Years 10-20	Global business services firm	- Move up-stack permanently: complex ops (claims, underwriting support, clinical admin), where judgement + empathy resist automation - Multi-country delivery (SA + Kenya/Egypt) for follow-the-sun coverage - The prize: owning client processes end-to-end under multi-year MSAs

How your KPIs change as you grow

Startup (years 1-2)

- Seat utilisation >85%
- QA/CSAT at or above client target
- Attrition <40%
- Cost per hire <R20k

Growth (years 3-5)

- Revenue per seat >R22k/mo offshore
- EBITDA >12%
- Client concentration <40%
- Absenteeism <5%
- Speed-to-competency <6 weeks

Scale (years 6-10+)

- EBITDA >18%
- Multi-year contract share >60%
- Outcome-priced revenue >25%
- Attrition <30%
- Net promoter score from clients >50

How clients are actually won and kept

Outbound — go get them

- BPO brokers/advisors in UK/US (they place campaigns for a fee) - the fastest route to offshore revenue without a sales office abroad
- Direct outreach to COOs/Heads of CX at mid-size UK/AUS firms (50-500 staff) too small for Teleperformance but big enough to outsource 10-30 seats
- Attend/exhibit at CCW, CX events in London; partner with CapeBPO/GBS SA trade missions - government actively brokers introductions
- Referral agreements with SA firms already serving those markets (software agencies, accountants) whose clients need back-office capacity

Inbound — make them come

- Rank for 'outsourcing to South Africa' comparison content (vs Philippines/India) - buyers research destination first, provider second
- Publish your operational metrics openly (attrition, QA, speed-to-competency) - operational transparency is rare and converts
- Impact-sourcing story (township employment, first-job creation) - global corporates' procurement teams score it in vendor selection
- Client video testimonials with accents your buyers recognise (UK/AUS voices vouching for SA delivery)

Retention — keep them

- Weekly ops reviews + monthly business reviews with improvement roadmaps - never let performance conversations happen only at renewal
- Embed continuous improvement: bring the client cost-reduction ideas before they ask (even when it cuts your seats - it wins the decade)
- Cross-train backup pods so client campaigns never feel key-person risk
- Grow share-of-wallet: start with one process, map their org for the next three

The 10-20 year game

- Generative AI eats simple voice work - the survivors sell outcomes, complex judgement work and AI-supervised hybrid teams; start that transition now
- SA's accent/empathy/timezone advantages matter more as work gets more complex, not less
- GBS incentives and a young English-speaking labour pool give SA a 10-15 year policy tailwind
- End-state: process ownership under long MSAs (quasi-infrastructure revenue) or strategic exit to a global GBS platform

9. Real Estate & Property Services

The smart way in: Enter through property services (income now, market knowledge free), build a rental portfolio through the cycle, then develop where the data says demand outruns supply.

How to get in — step by step

- 1 Qualify and pick a patch**
PPRA Fidelity Fund Certificate (candidate then full status), join an agency or open under a principal. Choose ONE suburb cluster or niche (student housing, sectional title rentals) and know it street by street.
- 2 Start with rentals, not sales**
Rental management pays monthly (8-12% of rent + placement fees) and builds the two assets that matter: landlord relationships and occupancy data. Sales commissions are lumpy; rentals compound.
- 3 Systematise management early**
PayProp/WeconnectU-type systems, credit vetting (TPN), inspection routines, arrears playbooks. 100 well-run units = R1.5m-R3m annuity revenue with tiny capital.
- 4 Buy your first units where you manage**
You see every deal first and know real yields. Target 9%+ net yield (affordable units, student rooms) with 60-70% bonds. Two units/year, never negative carry.
- 5 Add sectional-title/HOA management**
Body corporate management (R30-R60/unit/month at scale) is sticky annuity income and feeds sales/rental mandates from inside the schemes.
- 6 Develop only with pre-sales or pre-lets**
First development: small (6-20 units), in your proven patch, with 60%+ pre-sales or a rental underwrite before breaking ground. Development is where fortunes are made and lost - enter it from knowledge, not hope.

Your roadmap: what to hit, year by year

PHASE	FOCUS	REALISTIC TARGETS
Year 1	Licensed, first mandates	• 30-60 rental mandates under management, fee revenue R300k-R800k • Vacancy on managed book <6%; arrears <5% • Own deals analysed weekly (build the buy-list even before buying) • TPN/credit vetting on 100% of placements
Years 2-3	Management book + first own units	• 120-250 units managed, revenue R1.5m-R3.5m • 2-5 own rental units at >9% net yield, collections >97% • 1-2 body corporates under management • Landlord churn <10%/yr (the book is the business)
Years 4-5	Portfolio + first development	• 400+ managed units, revenue R5m-R10m; own portfolio 8-15 units • First micro-development: 6-20 units, GP margin >20%, 60%+ pre-sold • Own portfolio LTV <65%; interest cover >1.5x at stressed rates • Student/affordable niche position established (demand outruns supply 10:1)
Years 6-10	Developer-operator	• Development pipeline 50-200 units/yr in proven nodes • Own rental portfolio 30-80 units (R50m-R150m assets) self-managing through your own company • Revenue R20m-R60m across fees + development profits + net rentals • Institutional partnerships: equity partners/debt funds for bigger projects
Years 10-20	Property company	• Yield portfolio R200m-R1bn (opco/propco structure) • Affordable rental at scale - SA's structural shortage is your annuity • Possible REIT-feeder sale of stabilised assets, recycling capital into development • The management book (now thousands of units) remains the deal-flow and data engine underneath everything

How your KPIs change as you grow

Startup (years 1-2)

- Managed-book vacancy <6%
- Arrears <5%
- Mandate growth >5/month
- Landlord churn <10%

Growth (years 3-5)

- Own portfolio net yield >9%
- Collections >97%
- Development GP margin >20%
- Pre-sales before ground-break >60%
- Fee revenue covering all overheads (own portfolio is pure compounding)

Scale (years 6-10+)

- Portfolio LTV <60%
- Interest cover >2x
- Units developed/yr growing
- Cost per unit vs market <90%
- Tenant retention >70%/yr

How clients are actually won and kept

Outbound — go get them

- Direct outreach to landlords of visibly under-managed buildings (vacancy, arrears pain) with a rent-roll rescue pitch
- Body corporate trustees before AGM season with a management proposal + arrears-recovery track record
- Developers and investors for bulk rental mandates on new schemes (manage the whole building from day one)
- Estate late-payment/distressed lists, auctions and deceased estates for acquisition deal flow (attorney relationships are the source)

Inbound — make them come

- Own the suburb online: Google Business, suburb market reports ('what sold/rented in [suburb] this quarter'), local Facebook groups
- TPN/PayProp data-driven content for landlords (achieved rents, vacancy trends) - data authority converts landlords, not lifestyle content
- Property portals (Property24/Private Property) optimised listings - photography and response speed win the mandate war
- Student housing: relationships with university accommodation offices + NSFAS accreditation gets you listed on official channels

Retention — keep them

- Landlords: monthly statements that read like fund reports (yield, arrears, maintenance ROI) - treat every landlord like an investor client
- Tenants: fast maintenance response (the #1 churn driver), renewal offers 60 days out, upgrade paths within your portfolio
- Bodies corporate: transparent finances + visible compliance (CSOS, audits) - trustees renew what they don't have to defend
- Own tenants: keep rent increases at/below CPI for good payers - vacancy costs more than generosity

The 10-20 year game

- SA's housing shortfall (2m+ units) and rental demand are structural - affordable rental is a 20-year compounding trade
- Semigration and infrastructure decide geography: follow the Western Cape/KZN coast data, avoid decaying municipal nodes ruthlessly
- Rate cycles are your friend with patience: buy in high-rate distress, refinance in cuts
- End-state: the propco compounds wealth, the opco (management + development) compounds capability - build both, never confuse them

10. Healthcare & Wellness

The smart way in: Enter through cash-based primary care or B2B health services (where regulation permits non-clinician ownership), scale into multi-site delivery, then facilities where licensing is the moat.

How to get in — step by step

- 1 Map the ownership rules to your situation**
Clinicians can own practices; non-clinicians build in the permitted lanes: day hospitals, sub-acute/frail care facilities, home care agencies, occupational health companies, health-tech and admin services. Choose your lane accordingly.
- 2 Start cash-based, low-cost, high-volume**
The Unjani/low-cost clinic model proves it: nurse-led primary care at R250-R450 consultations serves the uninsured majority profitably. Cash removes the medical-scheme payment nightmare that sinks new practices.
- 3 Location = footfall + trust**
Taxi ranks, township main roads, retail centres near commuter flows. Partner with community leaders and existing pharmacies. Visibility and word-of-mouth beat any healthcare marketing.
- 4 Get licensing and billing right from day one**
Practice numbers (BHF), DoH facility licence where required, HPCSA/SANC compliance, and if billing schemes: coding discipline (rejection rate is a practice killer). A part-time practice manager pays for themselves.
- 5 Add B2B revenue early**
Occupational health contracts (mines, factories, farms need medicals by law), corporate wellness days, school screening programmes. B2B contracts smooth the cash-based consumer volume.
- 6 Scale sites on a repeatable model**
Document everything (clinical protocols, stock, staffing ratios) at site one. Sites 2-5 succeed on systems, not heroics. Day-clinic/facility licences come when your patient volumes prove the demand to funders.

Your roadmap: what to hit, year by year

PHASE	FOCUS	REALISTIC TARGETS
Year 1	One site, proven unit economics	• 15-30 patients/day by month 12, revenue R1m-R2.5m • Cash/hybrid mix >50% (scheme dependence <50%) • Claim rejection rate <5% on scheme billing • Break-even by month 8-10 • 1-2 occupational health/B2B contracts signed
Years 2-3	2-4 sites + B2B book	• Revenue R4m-R10m; each new site break-even <10 months • Patient volume per practitioner-day >22 • B2B/contract revenue >25% (occupational health, wellness) • Clinical protocols + stock systems documented (the scaling asset) • Staff: nurse-led model with sessional doctors - clinician cost <45% of revenue
Years 4-5	Multi-site group + first facility	• Revenue R15m-R35m, EBITDA 15-20% • 6-12 sites or 2-3 sites + day clinic licence application/build • Chronic programme patients >1,000 (repeat revenue backbone) • Telehealth + medicine delivery extending rural reach • Scheme network contracts (low-cost benefit options actively recruit cash-model networks)
Years 6-10	Healthcare platform	• Revenue R50m-R150m; 15-40 sites or facility group (day hospitals, sub-acute, frail care) • Frail/dementia care beds - the ageing insured cohort is the decade's certain demand • Funder contracts (capitation/DRG deals) - you're now infrastructure schemes need • Training pipeline: enrolled nursing partnerships feeding your own staffing
Years 10-20	Institutional health asset	• NHI-era positioning: accredited primary-care networks will be contracted whoever funds them - scale + accreditation + cost discipline wins either way • Facility portfolio (day hospitals, care facilities) = licensed, scarce, yield-bearing assets • Exit: hospital groups, funders and PE actively acquire primary-care networks and care facilities (8-12x EBITDA for scaled platforms)

How your KPIs change as you grow

Startup (years 1-2)

- Patients/practitioner-day >20
- Claim rejection <5%
- Cash mix >50%
- Cost per consultation <60% of fee

Growth (years 3-5)

- Site break-even <10 months
- Chronic/repeat patient share >30%
- B2B revenue >25%
- Clinician cost <45% of revenue
- Patient satisfaction >90% (measure it - funders ask)

Scale (years 6-10+)

- EBITDA >15%
- Bed/chair occupancy >70% (facilities)
- Funder-contracted revenue >30%
- Clinical incident rate at benchmark
- Staff retention >80% (scarcity makes this existential)

How clients are actually won and kept

Outbound — go get them

- Occupational health: direct proposals to mines, factories, farms, logistics depots (legally mandated medicals = guaranteed demand; bundle with wellness)
- Employer groups and unions for worksite clinic contracts and staff healthcare packages
- Medical scheme network teams: pitch inclusion in low-cost options and primary-care networks (they need footprint in underserved areas)
- Schools and creches for screening programmes (vision, hearing, immunisation catch-up) - low margin, high trust-building

Inbound — make them come

- Google Business + WhatsApp booking: 'clinic near me open now' is the highest-intent search in healthcare - own it with hours, prices, reviews
- Transparent pricing published (R350 consultation) - price certainty is the uninsured patient's #1 anxiety
- Community presence: taxi rank visibility, community radio health slots, church and stokvel health talks
- Patient reviews and word-of-mouth engineering (SMS review ask post-visit; township healthcare travels by word of mouth faster than any channel)

Retention — keep them

- Chronic care programmes (HIV, hypertension, diabetes) with medicine collection/delivery - monthly touchpoints = permanent patients
- Family files and continuity (same nurse relationship) - healthcare loyalty is personal, engineer the continuity
- SMS/WhatsApp follow-ups, results delivery and recall reminders
- B2B clients: quarterly utilisation and absenteeism-impact reports proving ROI to the HR director who signed you

The 10-20 year game

- Demographics are destiny: an ageing insured cohort (frail care demand) + a young uninsured majority (low-cost primary care demand) - both certain
- Clinician scarcity worsens for 20 years - models that leverage nurses, protocols and telehealth hold the cost advantage permanently
- NHI in any form needs contracted primary-care networks - scaled, accredited, cost-disciplined operators win under every scenario
- Facilities licensing scarcity = the moat deepens over time; licensed beds compound in value

11. Manufacturing

The smart way in: Enter as a niche job-shop or contract manufacturer where freight and lead times beat imports, secure energy independence early, then own products and export certification.

How to get in — step by step

- 1 Pick a niche imports serve badly**
Heavy/bulky relative to value (packaging, tanks, trailers), custom/short-run (CNC parts, shopfitting, technical textiles), fast-turnaround (signage, food co-packing), or regulated-local (defence/rail designations). Never compete with containers of generic goods.
- 2 Start in rented space with used equipment**
Industrial parks rent at R35-R70/m²; second-hand machinery is 40-60% off new. Capital belongs in working capital (materials, payroll through 60-day payment terms), not shiny machines.
- 3 Lock in an anchor customer's overflow**
Contract manufacturing/co-packing for a brand or OEM that's capacity-constrained. Their overflow is your base load; their standards force your quality systems to grow up fast.
- 4 Solve energy before it solves you**
Solar + storage sized to your shifts (budget 8-15% of setup capex). An interrupted production run destroys margins and delivery promises - energy independence is a competitive weapon in SA.
- 5 Get the certifications that gate demand**
ISO 9001 baseline, HACCP/FSSC for food, SABS/NRCS marks where regulated, B-BBEE level for corporate/public procurement, local-content designation registration. Each certificate unlocks a demand pool competitors can't enter.
- 6 Own a product by year 3**
Take the thing you make best under contract and launch your own SKU/brand into wholesale + online. Contract work funds the factory; own products own the margin.

Your roadmap: what to hit, year by year

PHASE	FOCUS	REALISTIC TARGETS
Year 1	Job-shop earning its keep	- Revenue R1.5m-R4m, gross margin >30% - Capacity utilisation >50% by month 12 1 anchor contract + 10-20 repeat SME customers - Quote turnaround <48 hours (speed is the small-shop weapon) - Zero energy-related missed deliveries
Years 2-3	Contract manufacturer with systems	- Revenue R6m-R18m; utilisation >70% - ISO/HACCP certification complete; reject rate <2% - On-time-in-full >95% - Top customer <35% of revenue - Own-product line launched (>10% of revenue by year 3)
Years 4-5	Certified, energy-independent, exporting	- Revenue R25m-R60m, EBITDA 12-16% - Own products >25% of revenue at >45% margin - First export orders (SADC first - logistics you can drive to) - Energy self-sufficiency >60% of consumption - Automation of the bottleneck process (not everything - the bottleneck)
Years 6-10	Scale plant + regional exports	- Revenue R80m-R250m - Export >20% of revenue (AfCFTA lanes, rand hedge) - Public procurement designations won where applicable (rail, defence, renewables components) - Second facility or 24/7 shifts; revenue per employee >R1.5m - Acquire a struggling competitor for capacity + book (plenty available)
Years 10-20	Industrial group	- Multi-plant, multi-product industrial company R300m-R1bn - Renewables/battery/EV component manufacturing as the energy transition localises supply chains - Own brands distributed continentally; contract base load underneath - Exit: industrial consolidators and PE buy certified, energy-independent plants with export books (5-7x EBITDA)

How your KPIs change as you grow

Startup (years 1-2)

- Utilisation >50%
- GM >30%
- Quote turnaround <48h
- DSO <45 days (payment terms discipline from day one)

Growth (years 3-5)

- Utilisation >75%
- OTIF >95%
- Reject rate <2%
- Energy cost <8% of revenue
- Own-product share >25%

Scale (years 6-10+)

- EBITDA >14%
- Revenue per employee >R1.5m
- Export >20%
- Inventory turns >8x
- Safety LTIFR at benchmark

How clients are actually won and kept

Outbound — go get them

- Direct to procurement at brands/OEMs with a capacity + certification + lead-time pitch (their import lead times are your opening)
- Retail buyers' local-supplier programmes and private-label tenders (retailers actively de-risk from import supply chains)
- Tender portals for designated local-content categories - but private sector first until you can carry government payment terms
- Industry cluster bodies and export councils (they broker buyer introductions and grant funding: dtic EMIA export incentives)

Inbound — make them come

- Rank for '[product] manufacturer South Africa' - genuine buyers search exactly this and competition is weak
- Factory content: capability videos, machine lists, certifications on a real website (most SA factories are invisible online - being visible wins)
- B2B marketplaces and directories (Made-in-SA type platforms, industry association member lists)
- Trade show presence in your niche (Propak, Electra Mining, NAMPO depending on sector) - one show, worked properly, fills a year's pipeline

Retention — keep them

- OTIF religion: track it, report it to customers before they measure it - supply reliability is why they left imports
- Vendor-managed inventory / call-off stock agreements that embed you in their planning
- Annual cost-down reviews sharing efficiency gains (procurement teams renew suppliers who help their KPIs)
- Co-development: prototype fast for their new products - the supplier in at design stage never gets tendered out

The 10-20 year game

- Global supply-chain regionalisation + AfCFTA + a weak rand = a 20-year window for African-based manufacturing
- Energy transition localises demand: solar mounting, electrical BOS, battery packs, e-mobility parts - position in the component chain
- Automation + energy independence neutralise SA's productivity gaps; adopt both faster than incumbents
- The compounding assets: certifications, export relationships and designated-supplier status - all take years and gate competitors out

12. Construction & Infrastructure

The smart way in: Enter as a specialised subcontractor with brutal cash discipline, climb CIDB grades on private + energy work, and only then touch development and public infrastructure at scale.

How to get in — step by step

- 1 Start specialised, not general**
Electrical, plumbing, HVAC, fire systems, waterproofing, solar structural, or shopfitting. Specialised trades price on skill; general building prices on desperation. Get trade-qualified staff and CIDB Grade 1-2 registration.
- 2 Serve private clients first**
Commercial fit-outs, franchise rollouts, body corporates, renewable EPCs, private developers. Government work at low grades = payment-delay roulette your balance sheet can't survive yet.
- 3 Run cash flow like a religion**
Deposit before mobilisation (30-50% on private work), weekly invoicing on measured progress, stop-work triggers at 30 days unpaid, DSO reported weekly. Most SA contractor deaths are cash deaths with profitable order books.
- 4 Price with a margin floor and walk away**
Cost every tender fully (prelims, retention finance, escalation), add minimum 12% margin at small scale, and decline work below it. Winning underpriced tenders is how you buy your own liquidation.
- 5 Climb CIDB grades deliberately**
Each grade unlocks bigger tenders; grades need track record + financial capability. Joint ventures with higher-grade contractors accelerate the climb while sharing risk.
- 6 Niche into the funded pipelines**
Renewable energy civils/structural, water infrastructure maintenance, affordable housing, logistics warehousing - the pockets where budgets are real and clients pay. Follow funded demand, not tender volume.

Your roadmap: what to hit, year by year

PHASE	FOCUS	REALISTIC TARGETS
Year 1	Specialised crew, private work	• Revenue R1.5m-R4m, net margin >10% • DSO <45 days; zero jobs started without deposit • CIDB Grade 2; SAFCEC/MBA membership for credibility • 10+ completed references with photos and sign-offs • Tender/quote win rate >1 in 6 at full margin
Years 2-3	Grade 4-5 contractor	• Revenue R8m-R20m; margin variance <3% vs tender • Retention + guarantee exposure <50% of free cash • 1-2 anchor client relationships (franchise rollouts, EPC frame agreements) giving repeat work • Site management systems (daily diaries, QA sign-offs, H&S files) audit-ready • First energy-sector contracts (solar civils/structures)
Years 4-5	Niche mid-tier	• Revenue R30m-R70m, EBITDA 8-12% • CIDB Grade 6-7; JV track record on larger projects • Specialised niche = >50% of book (energy, water, warehousing) • Owned plant only where utilisation >70%, else hire • Public work <30% of book and only with escalation + payment protections
Years 6-10	Grade 7-8 + development	• Revenue R100m-R300m • First own developments (JV equity in affordable housing/industrial units where you build at cost) • Framework agreements with IPPs, water boards, retail property funds • Professional team: QSEs, engineers, contracts managers - claims capability protects margin at this scale • Bonding/guarantee facilities R50m+ (the real constraint on growth)
Years 10-20	Infrastructure group	• Construction + development + O&M concessions (roads, water, energy assets need 20-year operators) • Public-private partnership positions as state capacity outsources • Annuity income (facilities management, O&M) >25% smoothing the cycle • Exit/succession: mid-tier contractors with niche books and clean balance sheets are scarce and acquirable

How your KPIs change as you grow

Startup (years 1-2)

- DSO <45 days
- Net margin >10%
- Win rate >1 in 6 at margin floor
- Rework <3% of contract value

Growth (years 3-5)

- Margin variance <3% vs tender
- Retention exposure <50% of free cash
- Repeat-client revenue >50%
- Claims recovered vs submitted >70%
- H&S: zero fatal incidents, LTIFR at benchmark

Scale (years 6-10+)

- EBITDA >10%
- Order book >12 months forward cover
- Guarantee facility headroom >30%
- Public-sector exposure <30%
- Development ROE >25% on JV equity

How clients are actually won and kept

Outbound — go get them

- Framework-agreement pitches to repeat builders: franchise brands, retail property funds, solar EPCs, warehouse developers - rollout clients beat tender lotteries
- Professional team relationships (architects, QSEs, engineers) who recommend contractors to their clients - breakfast circuit, site performance, prompt paperwork
- Selective tendering with a bid/no-bid scorecard (client payment reputation, site risk, margin) - capacity spent on bad tenders is capacity stolen from good ones
- Body corporates and property managers for maintenance/refurb annuity work between projects

Inbound — make them come

- Reference marketing: photographed, signed-off case studies per niche - construction buyers verify, they don't browse
- Google Business + '[trade] contractor [city]' SEO for private work flow
- CIDB registers and industry body directories where corporate procurement pre-screens
- Site boards, branded fleet and finished-project signage - still the highest-converting local advertising in this trade

Retention — keep them

- Finish snag-free and on date - the contractor who hands over clean gets the next phase without tender
- Post-completion service (12-month defect response within 48h) that makes you the default for the client's next project
- Transparent variation/claims communication early - surprises at final account end relationships
- Maintenance contracts on what you built (you know the building; annuity revenue smooths the pipeline)

The 10-20 year game

- SA's infrastructure backlog is generational (energy, water, housing, logistics) - the funded parts of it will build for 20 years
- State delivery capacity keeps outsourcing: PPPs, concessions and O&M contracts are where construction margins become infrastructure returns
- Alternative building tech (LSF, precast, modular) wins as skills scarcity and speed pressure grow - adopt early
- Survive the cycle, compound the reputation: in construction, longevity itself is the moat - most competitors won't still be there

13. Mining & Quarrying

The smart way in: Enter through mining services (no mining right needed), build multi-commodity client spread, then take positions in tailings retreatment and critical-minerals niches where juniors can win.

How to get in — step by step

- 1 Services first - always**
Drilling support, safety training and file management, rehabilitation, surveying/drone services, PPE and consumables supply, plant maintenance. Services revenue starts in months; mining rights take years.
- 2 Get compliant for site access**
CIPC + tax clearance + B-BBEE (procurement scoring is decisive in mining), COIDA letter of good standing, medicals and inductions for staff, and the MHSA safety file that gets you through the gate.
- 3 Land vendor numbers at 2-3 operations**
Mine procurement portals and supplier days; start with small POs delivered perfectly. A vendor number at a major is an asset worth more than equipment - protect it with flawless compliance.
- 4 Diversify commodity exposure deliberately**
Spread clients across coal, PGMs, chrome, manganese, iron ore - commodity cycles hit one at a time, and single-commodity service books die in downturns.
- 5 Move toward the resource with tailings**
Tailings retreatment (chrome from platinum dumps, gold from old slimes) needs processing skill + offtake, not deep-level mining capital. Permits are faster (the material is already mined) and ESG tailwinds help.
- 6 Only then consider a mining permit**
Small-scale mining permits (under 5ha) for chrome/aggregates/industrial minerals with a signed offtake. Full mining rights are a 3-5 year, R10m+ regulatory journey - enter it with cash flow, not hope.

Your roadmap: what to hit, year by year

PHASE	FOCUS	REALISTIC TARGETS
Year 1	Services foothold	• Revenue R2m-R5m from 2-3 mine clients • Vendor numbers at 3+ operations • Zero safety incidents / Section 54 triggers from your work • B-BBEE level 1-2 structured (it decides tender scoring) • One niche where you're demonstrably better (turnaround, tech, price)
Years 2-3	Multi-commodity service book	• Revenue R8m-R20m; 6-10 clients across 3+ commodities • Contract book >12 months forward revenue • No client >35% of revenue • Term contracts (1-3yr) >50% of book vs spot POs • Adjacent service lines added (one crew, multiple billable skills)
Years 4-5	Tailings/processing position	• Revenue R30m-R80m • First tailings retreatment JV or toll-processing arrangement (your plant, their dump, shared revenue) • Offtake agreement signed before plant commissioning • Processing margin >25%; recovery rates hitting design specs • Rehabilitation services line (guaranteed growth - closures accelerate)
Years 6-10	Junior operator	• Revenue R100m-R400m across services + processing + small-scale mining • Mining permit operations cash-flowing with contracted offtake (chrome/manganese/aggregates) • Critical-minerals exposure (manganese, vanadium, REE prospects) - the demand decade belongs to battery/energy metals • Own beneficiation step (crushing, washing, concentrating) capturing margin before export
Years 10-20	Mid-tier resources company	• Full mining right on a proven deposit, funded by the services/processing cash engine • Beneficiation ahead of raw-ore export restrictions (policy is moving this way across Africa) • Renewable-powered operations (cost + ESG + offtake advantage) • Exit paths: JSE/ASX listing, trade sale to mid-tiers hungry for developed assets, or hold as a cash-generative private producer

How your KPIs change as you grow

Startup (years 1-2)

- Safety incidents: zero
- Contract book >6 months
- Client concentration <40%
- PO-to-payment cycle <45 days

Growth (years 3-5)

- Forward contract cover >12 months
- Commodity spread: 3+
- Processing recovery vs design >95%
- EBITDA >15%
- B-BBEE procurement scoring maintained at level 1-2

Scale (years 6-10+)

- AISC below 80% of spot on owned production
- Offtake cover >80% of planned volumes
- Rehab liability fully funded/guaranteed
- Renewable energy share of power >40%
- Reserve life >10 years

How clients are actually won and kept

Outbound — go get them

- Mine procurement offices and supplier development programmes (majors have ESD budgets that fund and mentor local suppliers - use them)
- Mining indabas and commodity conferences (Junior Indaba, Mining Indaba) - deals and JVs are relationship-brokered in this industry
- Direct proposals to mine managers for pain-point services (rehab backlogs, safety file audits, water treatment) with fixed-price pilots
- Offtake traders (chrome/manganese buyers, commodity trading houses) - they'll co-fund production against supply agreements

Inbound — make them come

- Referrals via engineering consultancies and mine contractors already on site - be the subcontractor they trust
- Supplier databases and mining procurement platforms (vendor registration is inbound infrastructure)
- Technical case studies (recovery rates achieved, rehab hectares certified) in industry press - engineers buy on data
- ESG/local-content credentials visible: mines must procure local and empowered - make yourself the easy compliant choice

Retention — keep them

- Safety record as the relationship foundation: one incident can end a vendor number; over-invest in it
- Contract performance reporting aligned to the mine's own KPIs (availability, turnaround, compliance) every month
- Embed on site: dedicated crews who know the operation beat cheaper rotating outsiders
- Term-contract renewals negotiated 6 months early with productivity improvements offered proactively

The 10-20 year game

- The demand decade belongs to critical minerals (manganese, vanadium, chrome, REE) - position exposure there, not in deep-level gold/PGM decline
- Beneficiation policy pressure grows across Africa - owning a processing step future-proofs against raw-export restrictions
- Mine closures accelerate for 20 years: rehabilitation, closure management and tailings reprocessing are counter-cyclical growth markets
- The junior path is real but slow - let services and processing cash flow fund the resource positions, never the reverse

Final word

Every playbook here assumes the national baseline: most South African small businesses fail on cash flow, late payments and under-capitalisation - not bad ideas. The common thread across all thirteen playbooks: secure demand before capacity, keep months of runway banked, make compliance a weapon, own recurring revenue, and let annuity income - not adrenaline - fund each next step. Verify all figures against current market conditions before committing capital; this is research, not financial advice.